ADOLESCENT PEER GROUPS

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Peer groups are a major component in the adolescent development process. Adolescents face daily problems such as loneliness among their peers, rapid physical and emotional changes, fear of failure, and the constant search for their own identity. Adolescents engage in social relationships by joining identified groups.

The development of a personal identity is an essential part of the adolescent experience. As adolescents mature, they gain a greater understanding of their roles within their peer groups:

> The importance of developing social identity improves social skills, which helps build personal identity. By identifying with groups, teenagers place themselves into the peer system, which gives them a temporary identity while working toward a more concrete personal identity. Teenagers watch the other people in their groups and observe how they want or don't want to exist as an individual. The group members practice their social skills on each other as they observe each other as well. Since teenagers are starting to think more maturely and take other's perspectives into consideration, the actions they take among the group members help them realize what kind of person they are through the social skills they are practicing.

[1]These peer systems become particularly important in educational settings where adolescents spend a prolonged amount of time with the same group of peers.

High school teachers often consider how and why peer groups play such a key role in development. Secondary school teachers see this influence because "peer groups become more important during adolescence than during childhood. They play a significant role in the process of developing social

[1] Steinberg, Laurence, (ed.), Adolescence, 8th ed., McGraw-Hill Higher Education, Boston, 2008.

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